

QUEERNESS EXPERIENCES

TULUM GUIDEBOOK

A local, queer guide to the real Tulum: food, cenotes, beach clubs, nightlife, and everything nobody tells you before you arrive.

By Santi Solis (they/them) · queernessexperiences.com

● WELCOME

This is a list of my favorites, as a queer local. Every recommendation in here is somewhere I have personally been, eaten at, danced in, or trusted with my money and my body.

I'm Santi (they/them), queer, nonbinary, Mexican, and I've called Tulum home since 2017. I run Queerness Experiences, tours and group trips for queer and trans travelers. This guide is the free-flowing version of what I'd tell a friend the night before they land.

● MONEY & CURRENCY

Decline the conversion

Every ATM here (except BBVA) will ask if you want to "convert" your withdrawal to your home currency. Always decline: say no, or choose to be charged in pesos. It's a 5–15% markup dressed up as a favor. Let your own bank do the conversion instead.

There's no Uber

Tulum doesn't have Uber, which catches almost everyone off guard. Download **Eiby** before you land, it's the ride app locals actually use, and it'll get you fair prices instead of the tourist markup taxi charge.

● THE NATIONAL PARK (UPDATED AUG 2026)

Since the president visited in summer 2026, the rules changed in favor of visitors: entrance to the National Park is now **free**. A few caveats:

On foot or bike: free, through either the Tulum ruins entrance or the Cobá Road entrance.

By car or scooter: you need a reservation to drive/scoot in. Use Ikal (one of our favorite local beach clubs), fill out their form at ikaltulumhotel.com/access-registration and you're in, and they have their own parking lot.

No car or moto: go to either entrance, then take the little bus in for **20 pesos**.

Tulum ruins entrance fee: 265 pesos for non-local visitors.

● COFFEE

Story Horse

SPECIALTY COFFEE · TULUM CENTRO

A specialty coffee shop roasting its own beans, started by a Mexican-Irish couple (the name is the Irish way of saying hello, "what's the story, horse?"). Quietly one of the best cups in town. Baked goods, not a full breakfast menu.

Del Cielo

BREAKFAST · HEALTHY OPTIONS + MUNCHIES

"Del Cielo" means "from the sky," and the food lives up to it. Acai bowls, avocado toast, green juice, super yummy. Good whether you want something healthy or something more indulgent.

Bomba Snack

JUICE

Run by Fer, an awesome, super cool guy who makes genuinely great juice. A small spot, easy to miss, worth going out of your way for.

● WHERE TO EAT

All in town, except Arca and Hartwood, which are in the hotel zone.

Negro Huitlacoche

PRE-HISPANIC MEXICAN FOOD · VEGAN/VEGETARIAN/GF OPTIONS · JAM NIGHTS MONDAYS

My favorite restaurant in Tulum. Rooted in Mexican tradition with a creative twist. Order the corn. Monday nights are a local institution, with live jam sessions featuring the best musicians in town. Closed Tuesdays. Reservation recommended December–January.

Mestixa Tulum

MICHELIN BIB GOURMAND · RESERVATION REQUIRED

I have friends who fly to Tulum specifically to eat here. The baos are extraordinary. Book ahead.

Veleta Market

MULTI-VENDOR MARKET · EVENTS + PARTIES

Part food hall, part community hangout, part party venue. Don't leave without the pasta from Ciao Bella inside.

Burrito Amor

VEGAN/VEGETARIAN OPTIONS · A TULUM FIXTURE FOR 10+ YEARS

A reliable go-to in a town where most restaurants don't last two years. Good burritos.

● BARS & NIGHTLIFE

La Guarida

BAR · COMMUNITY CENTER · RESTAURANT

Part café, part rooftop bar, part cultural center: a bohemian maze of rooms with live music, jam sessions, workshops, and movie nights, built around community rather than a tourist crowd. At night, different rooms often host different parties, each with its own theme. If you only go to one bar in Tulum, make it this one.

Negro Huitlacoche, Monday jam nights

Yes, it's on the food page too, but the Monday night jam session is a big enough deal to mention here again. Live music, local musicians, a real local institution.

Palma Central

SALSA TUESDAYS

Starts with a beginner-friendly salsa lesson, then a mix of DJ sets and live music. Non-negotiable, one of the best group nights out in town.

Cara Feliz

KARAOKE, MOST NIGHTS

Super fun: multiple microphones so more than one person can sing at once, and air conditioning, which matters more than you'd think.

La Pizzine

TWO LOCATIONS: LA VELETA + PUEBLO (TOWN)

Pizza with real live music venues. Both locations throw parties on different nights, check [@la_pizzinetulum](#) for what's on where.

There's no dedicated "gayborhood" here. Tulum's queer scene is woven into daily life rather than concentrated in one area. Red Room exists as a bar, but leans specifically toward gay men. For a broader queer-friendly night, La Guarida above is the real recommendation.

● THINGS I LOVE TO DO

If you're not booking a tour and you're in the area a while, I do a lot of activities myself, you're welcome to join:

Jiu-jitsu

Open mat: [instagram.com/openmat.mujeres](https://www.instagram.com/openmat.mujeres)

Dance class, life drawing night, theatre in Spanish

And whatever else is happening that week. Message us and we'll point you to what's on.

● BEACH CLUBS

Most of Tulum's famous beach clubs charge mandatory minimums, valet fees, and tourist prices. These do not, or at least they're honest about what you're paying for.

Ikal, the local favorite

This is where Tulum locals actually go. The most reasonable prices on the coast, and the vibe is unmatched. Arriving by car or moto now requires a reservation to enter the National Park (see the Money & Park page), fill out Ikal's form at ikaltulumhotel.com/access-registration and you're set. Walking or biking in doesn't require a reservation.

Arena

POWERED BY IKAL (SAME TEAM) · OPEN WED–MON, 8AM–7PM

Same team as Ikal, just a smaller stretch of beach and a genuinely local-friendly crowd. Mediterranean food from Mera Spiaggia, sunbeds, cocktails, occasional music and community events. I haven't been myself, but friends who go regularly love it.

Dos Ceibas

NO MINIMUM · BEACH BEDS · QUEER-FRIENDLY CROWD · 2-FOR-1 DRINKS AFTER 5PM

The pizzas are delicious, 200–300 pesos. Get there early for a beach bed. Great energy.

Delek

NO MINIMUM · NO PARKING · RELAXED VIBE

Calm, quiet, fewer people. Easy on a moto or bike. Good for a chill afternoon.

● GIVING BACK

Outside of tours, I'm on the committee for Los Amigos de la Esquina (LADLE), a local nonprofit offering art, wellbeing, and life-skills programs for Mayan and local Mexican kids. I started there as a volunteer, later became general manager, and now help guide the organization from the committee. If you want to give back while you're here, this is where I'd point you.

WANT MORE THAN A GUIDEBOOK?

Come explore Tulum with me directly. Small-group tours to the cenotes, the food scene, and the town behind the town: queernessexperiences.com/tours

Thanks for reading. See you in Tulum.
Santi